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THE WHITE HOUSE

WASHINGTON

MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telcon with Prime Minister Giulio Andreotti
of Italy (U)

PARTICIPANTS: The President
Giulio Andreotti, Prime Minister
Notetaker: Robert Hutchings, NSC Staff
Interpreter: Sim Smiley

DATE, TIME January 21, 1991, 9:49 - 10:04 a.m.
AND PLACE: Camp David

The President initiated the call. (U)

The President: Prime Minister, how are you today? (U)

Prime Minister Andreotti: Good morning. How are you? (U)

The President: I am fine. I am just calling to touch base and give you an updated report on the way we think the situation is going in the Gulf. (U)

Prime Minister Andreotti: Thank you very much. I am very pleased. (U)

The President: First, let me express my condolences over the loss of one of your pilots. I don't know if it has been confirmed whether he is dead or alive, but let us hope he is alive. (U)

Prime Minister Andreotti: We have almost certain confirmation that he is alive, though he has been taken prisoner. (U)

The President: I don't like what Saddam Hussein is doing -- parading these prisoners, against the Geneva Convention. It is not surprising, but it is disgraceful. It is cruel and brutal. (U)

Prime Minister Andreotti: Right. (U)

The President: Basically, let me just make a few points. Then I would particularly like to hear your views. First, the air campaign has gone even better than we thought it would when we were planning it. The weather the last couple of days has been bad, so we have had to reduce the number of sorties. The

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technical equipment is working well; thus we are convinced we have kept the loss of innocent life to a minimum in Baghdad and Iraq. We will continue the air campaign. We have already started to work on Republican Guard units in southeastern Iraq and across into Kuwait. Your planes and ours control the air. There have been eleven challenges from Iraqi aircraft, and they have lost all eleven fights. The danger to our pilots comes largely from anti-aircraft fire, because we have been able to suppress most SAM sites. (S)

I still worry about the Israel card. Saddam Hussein knows what he is doing in trying to draw Israel into the war, hoping it will ruin the coalition. So far Shamir has been quite reasonable, given Israel's history of fighting back right away against aggression, but it will be hard to ask them not to do anything if they get hit a third time. Basically, the coalition is holding well, and public opinion is holding pretty well, including in the U.S. The longer it goes, the more public demonstrations probably will take place. But I wanted you to know that I am more determined than ever to finish this job, and that means full compliance with the UN Security Council resolutions -- especially getting out of Kuwait. We have avoided making predictions about how long this will last, because we simply don't know exactly what the bomb damage has been or what Saddam Hussein has up his sleeve. It is my view, given the disruption of communication, that Saddam does not know of the damage to some of his forces and installations in outlying areas. This is about the situation right now. We are pleased that the Patriot missiles seem to be defending against Scud missiles very well. That's about the way I see it. I would love to have your views, my friend. (S)

Prime Minister Andreotti: My view is that public opinion understands more and more that what we are dealing with is to make sure the UN resolutions are fully applied. If the UN is unable to reach these goals, including the liberation of Kuwait, this will be a defeat for the entire international community. It is not a war between Iraq and the U.S. but between Iraq and the UN. I wanted to tell you, Mr. President, that your speech on October 1 at the UN was very important -- that is, no linking, but as soon as the Kuwaiti problem is solved then we should address the Palestinian problem. (U)

The President: We have to do that, yes. (U)

Prime Minister Andreotti: The message you delivered a few days ago also expressed this idea very clearly. The more often you can express this view, the better it is for the Arab world. That is our opinion. We will try to stay in touch with the Maghreb and help them resist the fundamentalist position. This sums up my thinking, Mr. President. I would like to express my best hopes and best prayers to you. (U)

The President: Thank you. We will stay in touch. If you have any thoughts or questions, don't hesitate to call. (U)

Prime Minister Andreotti: Thank you. I will very gladly do so.
Good-bye. (U)

The President: Good-bye, Giulio. (U)

-- End of Conversation --